

Lecture 5: Participation and Representation (FK)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: OD ch. 6 (*Institutions of Participation and Representation*)

Theme of the lecture: Why do some citizens participate while others don't? Why are some interests represented while others aren't? We examine how different institutions — specifically electoral and party systems — shape political participation and representation.

OD Ch. 6 — Institutions of Participation and Representation

Book: Orvis & Drogus, *Introducing Comparative Politics*, 5th ed., ch. 6.

Chapter résumé

Looks at the three institutions through which democracies channel **participation and representation** — **electoral systems**, **parties/party systems**, and **civil society (interest groups)** — and asks which best represent ordinary and marginalised citizens. It opens with *why anyone participates at all* (a collective-action problem), then its analytic core: how **electoral systems** (plurality/SMD · majoritarian · PR · mixed) convert votes into seats and thereby shape the **number of parties (Duverger's Law)**, proportionality, stability, and the representation of women & minorities. It classifies **party systems**, surveys how parties mobilise (programmatic / clientelist / populist) amid a "crisis of party democracy," contrasts **pluralist vs neocorporatist** interest-group systems, and closes on the master **trade-off (Powell): diverse representation ⇒ clear accountability**.

★ The heart of the chapter: institutions decide who participates and whose interests get represented. The **electoral system** is the master lever — **SMD/plurality** squeezes politics toward *two parties + clear accountability but wasted votes*; **PR** opens it to *many parties + proportional, diverse representation but coalition instability* (Duverger's Law). Underneath sits one unavoidable **trade-off (Powell): broad representation ⇒ clear accountability/governability**.

The red thread. Two questions run through the chapter. ① **Why participate (or not)?** — voting is individually "irrational" (a collective-action problem), so *institutions* raise or lower the cost (PR & simple systems → higher turnout). ② **Whose interests get represented?** — the electoral system → party system → interest-group system chain decides. For any case ask: **how do votes become seats · how many parties result · who gets left out (small parties, women, minorities) · and what's traded off (representation vs accountability)?**

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- The electoral-system menu: **SMD plurality (FPTP) · majoritarian (two-round / alternative vote) · proportional representation (PR) · mixed/semiproportional.**
- Duverger's Law — SMD → two parties; PR → multiparty.
- **Party systems** — dominant-party · two-party · multiparty; **sociological** (cleavages) vs **institutional** (electoral rules) origins.

- **Mobilisation types** — programmatic • patronage/clientelist • populist.
- **Interest groups: pluralism** (many, neutral state — US) vs **neocorporatism** (few peak associations bargain with the state — Germany).
- **The Powell trade-off** — representation/participation $\rightleftharpoons$ accountability/governability.

Section-by-section main points

Lecture frame (FK). The lecture opens by asking *what representation even is* (**Pitkin**), then works through the institutions that produce it — **electoral systems** → **party systems** → **civil society** — and closes with **case studies** (UK, Germany, Japan, Brazil).

| What is representation? — Pitkin's four views

Core: before asking *how* institutions represent, ask *what "representation" means*. **Hanna Pitkin** (*The Concept of Representation*, 1967) distinguishes **four** senses:

- **Formalistic** — the institutional arrangement that **authorises** a representative and holds them **accountable** (elections = the "before" and "after" of representing).
- **Descriptive** — the representative **resembles** the represented (shares gender, ethnicity, class) — "**standing for**" (the case for **quotas** / descriptive representation).
- **Symbolic** — the representative **stands for** the represented symbolically (a leader/flag people identify with).
- **Substantive** — the representative **acts in the interests** of the represented — "**acting for**" (the **delegate** [follow instructions] vs **trustee** [own judgment] debate).
- *Why it matters:* the electoral systems below are really machines for producing one kind of representation or another — **PR** boosts **descriptive** representation (more women/minorities); **SMD** emphasises the **formalistic** local link.

| Why participate? — the collective-action problem

Core: voting is individually "**irrational**" (Downs) — one vote rarely decides anything — so participation is a **collective-action problem** that *institutions* must overcome.

- People vote anyway for **expressive/solidaristic** reasons, charismatic leaders, and to avoid the **emotional cost** of not participating (guilt, exclusion).
- **Institutions shape turnout:** complex systems depress it among the less-educated; **PR/mixed systems raise it** (fewer "wasted votes"); parties & interest groups lower the cost of finding and acting on your interests.

| Electoral systems — *the core of the chapter* ★

Core: the electoral system is the master lever — *on what basis are you represented* (a **district**, a **party/idea**, or a **group**), and *how do votes become seats*?

System	Votes → seats	Parties (Duverger)	Proportionality	Turnout	Women/minorities	Cases
SMD plurality (FPTP)	most votes in each district wins (no majority needed)	two parties	low (wasted votes)	lower	worse	<u>UK</u> , <u>US</u> , <u>India</u>
Majoritarian (two-round / AV ranked-choice)	need 50%+1 → runoff or reallocate	~two blocs	low-medium	—	—	France
Proportional (PR) — <u>closed/open list</u>	seats = vote share (national/large districts, a threshold)	multiparty	high	higher	better	<u>Israel</u> , <u>Brazil</u> (open)
Mixed / semiproportional	SMD seats + party-list PR	multiparty	high (compensatory , <u>Germany</u>) / medium (noncompensatory , <u>Japan</u>)	higher	—	Germany, Japan

- **SMD/FPTP: strengths** — strong voter-representative link, single-party government (efficient, accountable); defenders also invoke **virtual representation** (co-partisans elected in *other* districts speak for you). *Weaknesses* — **wasted votes**, **disproportionality** (a party can win many seats on ~35% pluralities; a broad-but-thin party wins almost none), gerrymandering, fewer women/minorities. (*Empirically the SMD "closer link" is weak* — Curtice & Shively found no real advantage in voter-rep contact.)
- **PR: strengths** — few wasted votes, **higher turnout**, far **more women & minorities** (lists + quotas), more information/positions, more egalitarian policy (Orellana). *Weaknesses* — no identifiable individual rep, **coalition instability**, small extremist parties gain outsized leverage; **Kedar**: PR voters even vote for *more extreme* parties on purpose, expecting post-election compromise to pull policy back to the middle.
 - **Closed vs open list** — *who decides the order within a party's seats?* Under PR you vote for a **party**, which then fills its won seats from a ranked **list of candidates**. The two variants differ in *who sets that rank*:
 - **Closed list**: the **party** fixes the order in advance; you vote only for the party, and if it wins *n* seats they go to the top *n* names on the party's list. → **more party control, party discipline, and easy use of quotas** (a party can guarantee women high spots), but voters can't pick the *individual*. (e.g. Israel.)
 - **Open list**: you vote for the party **and** for a **specific candidate** within it; the candidates' *own* vote totals decide who gets the party's seats. → **more voter choice over individuals**, but it makes candidates compete against their *own* party-mates → **weaker, more personalist parties**. (e.g. Brazil — a big reason its parties are so fragmented and weak.)
- **Mixed**: two ballots (a district candidate + a party list) — blends a personal rep with proportional fairness; **Germany's compensatory** version tops seats up to full proportionality, **Japan's noncompensatory** version keeps SMD & PR separate (less proportional). **AV/ranked-choice** wastes fewer votes than FPTP (Maine 2018 elected the first US Congress seat by AV).
 - **Is Germany still "mixed"? (2023 reform)**. You can argue it's **drifting toward pure PR**. Germany's compensatory mechanism caused the Bundestag to balloon (**736 seats in 2021** via overhang + balance

seats). The **2023 reform** (first used in the **2025** election) **capped the house at 630** and **abolished overhang & compensatory seats**: a party now gets **only** the seats its **second (list) vote** earns, and district winners are seated **only if their party's list vote covers them** (*Zweitstimmendeckung*) — otherwise the narrowest district winners **lose their seats** even though they won locally. So the **first vote no longer guarantees a personal representative**, and total seats are set almost entirely by the party vote → many now call it "**personalised PR**" rather than a genuine mixed system. (*The Constitutional Court upheld the cap in 2024 but reinstated the basic-mandate/3-seat clause.*)

- **Redistribution link (Iversen & Soskice — from Lecture 4): PR → the middle class allies with the poor → bigger welfare states**; majoritarian → middle allies with the rich → less. A key reason electoral systems shape *policy*, not just seats (the Sweden vs US welfare puzzle).

| Duverger's Law — and its limits

Core: SMD/plurality → **two parties** (small parties get squeezed out and voters stop "wasting" votes on them); PR → **multiparty**.

- **But not deterministic:** it holds in *established* democracies; in **new/diverse** democracies voters aren't strategic (ethnic/identity voting persists), so FPTP can still produce many parties (Moser & Scheiner) — see **India**. And it can break even in old democracies (**France 2017**: Macron's one-year-old party upended a near-two-party system).

| Party systems

Core: classify by **number & strength**: **dominant-party** (S. Africa ANC — won every election) · **two-party** (US, UK) · **multiparty** (Italy — coalitions required).

- **Where party systems come from — two explanations:**
 - **Sociological:** parties reflect social **cleavages** — an economic **capital vs labour** split everywhere, *plus* a religious split in some places. Where *both* are salient → **multiparty**; where only economic → **two-party**.
 - **Institutional (Duverger):** rational politicians build parties to win *under the given electoral rules* — SMD squeezes toward two.
- **Bridging the "chicken-and-egg":** the institutional effect holds in **established** democracies but *not* in **new** ones, where voters aren't strategic (ethnic/identity voting persists, FPTP winners take seats on 20–30%) — Boix; Moser & Scheiner. **France** is the classic Duverger case (its two-round SMD pushed a fragmented system to ~two blocs, 82% of seats by 2012) — until **2017**, when Macron's one-year-old party blew it up.

| How parties mobilise — and the "crisis of party democracy"

Core: parties win support three ways — **programmatic** (ideas/ideology) · **patronage/clientelist** (material benefits for votes, via **brokers** — common in poorer/newer & statist economies) · **populist** (a personalist leader, "the people" vs "corrupt elites," crisis rhetoric, "bad manners").

- **Where parties sit — two ideology axes (FK):** the classic **economic Left–Right** (redistribution) *plus* the modern cultural **GAL–TAN** — **GAL** (Green/Alternative/Libertarian: progressive, cosmopolitan, pro-environment, individual rights) vs **TAN** (Traditional/Authoritarian/Nationalist). Today's populist/far-right parties (Farage, Salvini, AfD) mobilise mainly on the **TAN** end of this second axis.
- **Caveat on "programmatic": Achen & Bartels** ("folk theory" critique) argue voters mostly vote by **social identity**, not by carefully weighing ideas — so pure programmatic appeal is partly a myth.

- **Crisis of party democracy:** only ~20% trust parties (though ~80% value democracy); falling loyalty/membership/turnout, rising **electoral volatility**, single-issue/postmaterialist voting, and **far-right/anti-system** parties (nativism, post-2015 refugee crisis). Explanations: economic (globalisation, manufacturing decline); **dealignment** (voters detach from all parties) vs **realignment** (they switch); catch-all parties → "**cartel parties**" (Mair) colluding at the centre → lost efficacy.
- **US exception:** not dealignment but partisan **sorting/polarisation** (Abramowitz), racial realignment, and Trump's **status-threat** populism (Mutz 2018).

Civil society & interest groups — pluralism vs neocorporatism

Core: beyond parties, organised **interest groups** (they *don't* seek office, unlike parties) represent society — in two rival models. Groups grew sector-by-sector: first **labour, business, agriculture**, then **women/minority** groups; in divided societies, ethnic/religious groups dominate (some, like the KKK, are internally *undemocratic* — a tension for democracy).

- **Pluralism** (US): **many** competing groups, a **neutral** state; easy entry & local control, but fragmented clout — and **business is inherently privileged** (Lindblom). **Schattschneider's** famous jab: "*the flaw in the pluralist heaven is that the heavenly chorus sings with a strong upper-class accent*" — i.e. who gets organised is skewed toward the well-off.
- **Neocorporatism** / societal corporatism (Germany, N. Europe): a **few large, hierarchical peak associations** the state recognises as *the* voice of each sector negotiate **binding** deals; more influence (esp. for labour countering business) but **less participatory** (little incentive to form new groups). (*State corporatism = the mandated, authoritarian version — ch. 8.*)
- **Social-capital debate:** Putnam (*Bowling Alone*) sees civic **decline**; Skocpol adds that mass-membership bodies gave way to **managed advocacy**; critics (Dalton, "**Kicking in Groups**") reply that activity just **moved to new forms** (movements, single-issue groups).

The master trade-off (Powell)

Core: systems open to **diversity** (PR · multiparty · pluralism) maximise **representation & participation** but blur **accountability & governability**; **majoritarian** systems (FPTP · two-party) do the reverse. *There is no free lunch — every design chooses a point on this line.* The chapter's most robust finding: **PR represents women far better than SMD** (India goes further with **reserved seats**).

Cases & examples

Why these cases are here — circle them back. Each shows **one electoral/party system in action** and *who it represents vs leaves out*. Read each for: *which system · how votes became seats · who got left out.*

Case	Electoral system	Party system	What it shows
UK	SMD/FPTP	two-party	extreme disproportionality (UKIP 12.6% → 1 seat)
Germany	mixed compensatory PR	multiparty	how mixed PR lets new parties (Greens, AfD) in
Japan	mixed noncompensatory	dominant (LDP)	more majoritarian; Duverger working haltingly
India	SMD/FPTP + federal	multiparty	Duverger's limits in a diverse democracy; reserved seats
Brazil	open-list PR (no threshold)	fragmented	weak-party fragmentation (30 parties) + populism
Israel	pure closed-list PR	hyper-multiparty	PR instability under extreme diversity

- **UK — SMD/FPTP.** The paradigm two-party FPTP system: modest vote margins → big seat majorities → single-party government. But it's wildly **disproportional** — in **2015, UKIP won 12.6% of the vote → 1 seat**, while the **SNP won fewer votes → 56 seats** (geographically concentrated in Scotland). → *SMD/FPTP → disproportionality, wasted votes, majoritarian governance.*
- **Germany — mixed compensatory PR.** Designed after Weimar with a **5% threshold** + compensatory mixed PR → a stable multiparty system. The **Greens (1983)** got in *because* the semiproportional system let them clear the threshold (unlike Britain's Greens); by **2017** the two big parties fell to a record **54%**, and the far-right **AfD** won its first seats. **Note (2023 reform):** to stop the house ballooning (736 seats in 2021), Germany **capped it at 630** and **scrapped overhang/compensatory seats** — seats now follow the **list vote** and a district win no longer guarantees a seat, so it's arguably become **personalised PR** rather than truly "mixed." → *Mixed PR sustains a multiparty system and lets new/ideological parties gain representation — though the 2023 reform pushes it toward pure PR.*
- **Japan — mixed noncompensatory.** The **LDP dominated 1955–93** via factions & clientelism; the **1994 reform** (300 SMD + 180 PR, *noncompensatory*) pushed toward two parties — the **DPJ won 308/480 in 2009**, but the **LDP swept back in 2012** ("lucky, not popular" — a split opposition). → *Noncompensatory mixed = more majoritarian than Germany; Duverger's Law working haltingly.*
- **India — FPTP in a diverse federation.** FPTP "should" give two parties, but **huge diversity + federalism** yields many *state-level* two-party fights that aggregate into a **national multiparty** system (parties: 50 in 1952 → 342 in 2009). **BJP (Modi) 2014: 31% of the vote → 52% of seats** under FPTP. **120 of ~600 seats are reserved** for lower castes/tribes. → *Duverger's limits in a new/diverse democracy; reserved-seat representation.*
- **Brazil — open-list PR, no threshold.** No incentive for intra-party cooperation → extreme fragmentation (**30 parties by 2018**) and weak, local parties (a third of legislators switched parties 1989–95). Recession + the "car wash" scandal → mass protests → **Rousseff impeached (2016)** → outsider populist **Bolsonaro won 2018** atop a tiny party. → *Open-list PR's weak-party fragmentation + accountability failure + populism.*
- **Israel — pure PR.** The whole country is **one district**, a 120-seat Knesset, **3.25% threshold** → ~a dozen parties win; governments = a big party + 3–6 small ones, lasting ~2 years; **2019 produced three elections in one year.** → *PR's instability under extreme diversity — the cost of maximal proportionality.*

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Collective-action problem	Individuals rationally don't act (vote) though all suffer if none do
Electoral system	Legal mechanism translating votes into offices/seats
Single-member district (SMD)	Each district elects one representative
Plurality / FPTP	Most votes wins (no majority needed)
Majoritarian / Alternative vote	Winner needs 50%+1 (runoff / ranked-choice)
Proportional representation (PR)	Seats = vote share (national/large districts + a threshold)
<u>Closed-list PR</u>	Vote for a party; the party sets the candidate order (party control, quotas) — Israel
<u>Open-list PR</u>	Vote for party and a candidate; candidates' own votes set the order (voter choice, weaker parties) — Brazil
Mixed / semiproportional	SMD seats + party-list PR (compensatory / noncompensatory)
Duverger's Law	SMD → two parties; PR → multiparty
Party system	Number & strength of parties (dominant / two-party / multiparty)
Programmatic / patronage / populist mobilisation	Win support by ideas / material rewards / anti-elite personalism
Interest-group pluralism	Many competing groups, neutral state (US)
Neocorporatism	Few peak associations bargain binding deals with the state (Germany)
Peak association	Body uniting a whole sector to negotiate with the state
Social capital	Networks + norms of reciprocity underpinning civil society
Powell trade-off	Diverse representation ⇔ clear accountability

Exam pointers

- Reproduce the electoral-systems comparison cold — how each converts votes→seats, its effect on the **number of parties (Duverger)**, **proportionality**, **turnout**, and **women/minorities** — with a case each.
- Answer both spine questions: **why participate** (collective-action problem; institutions shape turnout) and **whose interests get represented** (electoral → party → interest-group chain).
- State Duverger's Law and its limits (India; France 2017).
- Contrast pluralism vs neocorporatism (US vs Germany) for interest representation.
- Land on the Powell trade-off (representation ⇔ accountability) and the robust finding that **PR represents women better**; use Iversen & Soskice to link PR → more redistribution.

★ Fun facts & memorable details

Sticky stats, dates & quotes from Lecture 5 (participation & representation).

Quotable

- Schattschneider (1942): "*Modern democracy is unthinkable save in terms of parties.*"
- Downs (1957): for most people, voting is technically **irrational** — the seed of the collective-action problem.
- Powell's master **trade-off**: representation/participation $\rightleftharpoons$ accountability/governability.

Striking numbers

- **UK 2015**: UKIP won **12.6%** → **1 seat**; the SNP won *fewer* votes → **56 seats**.
- **US 2012 House**: in the ten most gerrymandered states, Republicans won **7% more votes but 76% more seats**.
- **Israel**: whole country = one district; **3.25% threshold**; **three elections in one year (2019)**; governments last ~2 years.
- **India**: parties grew **50 (1952) → 342 (2009)**; **120 of ~600** seats reserved for lower castes/tribes; BJP 2014 = **31% of vote → 52% of seats**.
- **Brazil 2018**: its most fragmented legislature ever — **30 parties**.
- **Women in legislatures**: Nordic countries lead at **42.5%**; US House only **23.4%** (2019). Robust finding: **PR elects more women than SMD**.
- Only ~**20%** of citizens trust parties, though ~**80%** call democracy "a very good thing."
- **Maine 2018**: first US Congress seat decided by **ranked-choice** — Golden won 50.5–49.5 after trailing on the first count.

Memorable

- **France**: the top two parties held **56% of Assembly seats (1973) → 82% (2012)** — then the system **collapsed in 2017** with Macron's one-year-old party.
 - ~**60 countries** used FPTP in 2019 — almost all former British colonies; **Belarus** was the only continental-European one.
 - The social-capital debate in two titles: Putnam's *Bowling Alone* vs its rebuttal "**Kicking in Groups**."
-